

Topic 7: Role and Persona Prompting

7.1 What is Role Prompting?

- Role prompting assigns the model an identity or expertise before the task
- Activates relevant knowledge and adjusts tone, vocabulary, and depth of response
- Simple form: 'You are a [role].' at the start of the system prompt or user prompt
- The model doesn't 'become' the role -- it adjusts its probability distribution toward language typical of that role
- Most effective when the role is well-represented in training data: doctor, lawyer, chef, teacher, engineer

7.2 Effective Role Definitions

- Be specific: 'You are a board-certified cardiologist' is stronger than 'You are a doctor'
- Add context: 'You are a senior Python developer at a fintech startup focused on security'
- Set behaviour: 'You are a strict code reviewer who prioritises readability over cleverness'
- Set communication style: 'You explain things using analogies and avoid jargon'

WEAK role:

You are a teacher. Explain machine learning.

STRONG role:

You are an experienced high-school physics teacher who specialises in making abstract concepts concrete using everyday analogies.

Your students are 16 years old with no programming background.

Explain how a neural network learns, using a relatable analogy.

Keep the explanation under 200 words.

7.3 Persona Prompting for Consistency

- Persona prompting is role prompting applied to maintain a consistent identity across a conversation
- Used to build: customer service bots, AI tutors, brand voice assistants
- Define: name, personality, knowledge scope, things the persona will NOT do
- Repeat key persona details if the conversation is long -- they can fade from influence

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You are Aria, a friendly customer support assistant for TechStore.  
Personality: warm, patient, solution-focused, never sarcastic.  
Knowledge: TechStore products, return policies, order tracking.  
Scope: only answer questions about TechStore. For off-topic questions,  
        politely redirect: 'I am only able to help with TechStore queries.'  
Tone: professional but conversational. Use the customer's name if provided.
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7.4 Limitations of Role Prompting

- The model cannot truly simulate a specific real person -- it approximates based on public information
 - Roles do not unlock hidden capabilities -- they shift tone and vocabulary, not knowledge
 - Avoid asking the model to roleplay as a real individual in misleading contexts
 - For critical domains (medical, legal): add 'Always remind the user to consult a licensed professional'
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